# Exchanging Greetings

## Dialogue 1

At school, Wang Peng and Li You meet each other for the first time.

Audio

Video

你好[a]！

你好！

请问[b]，你[c]贵姓？

我姓[1]*李。你呢[2]？

我姓王。李小姐[d]，你叫[3]什么名字？

我叫李友。王先生，你叫什么名字？

我叫王朋[4]。

### Pinyin Dialogue

*Nǐ hǎo*[a]!

*Nǐ hǎo!*

*Qǐng wèn*[b], *nǐ*[c] *guì xìng?*

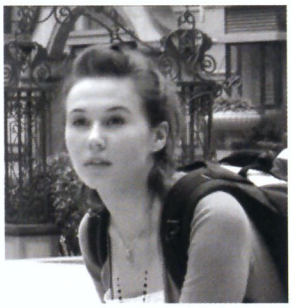
*Wǒ xìng*[1] *Lǐ. Nǐ ne*[2]*?*

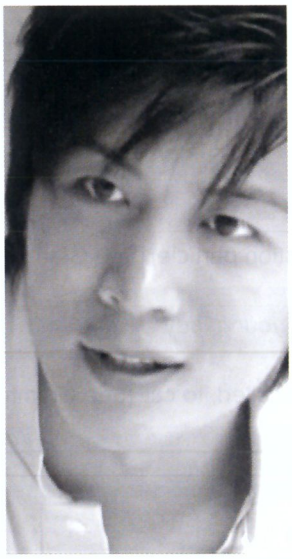
*Wǒ xìng Wáng. Lǐ xiǎojiě*[d], *nǐ jiào*[3] *shénme míngzi?*

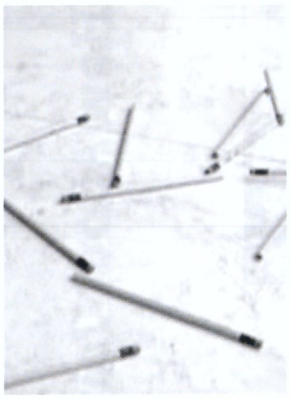
*Wǒ jiào Lǐ Yǒu. Wáng xiānsheng, nǐ jiào shénme míngzi?*

*Wǒ jiào Wáng Péng*[4].

* Here and throughout the book, the blue lesson text and numbers correspond to explanations in the **Grammar section.**







**a** 你好! *(Nǐ hǎo!)*

This common greeting is used to address strangers as well as old acquaintances. To respond, simply repeat the same greeting.

**b** 请问 *(qǐng wèn)*

This is a polite phrase used to get someone's attention before asking a question or making an inquiry, similar to "excuse me, may I ask" in English.

**c** 你 *(nǐ)* vs. 您 *(nín)*

To be more polite and respectful, replace 你 *(nǐ)* with its honorific form, 您 *(nín)*. [See Language Note A, Dialogue 1, Lesson 6.]

**d** 小姐 *(xiǎojiě)*

This is a word with two third-tone syllables. The tone sandhi rule applies, thus making the first third tone, 小 *(xiǎo)*, a second tone. The second syllable, 姐 *(jiě)*, can also be pronounced in the neutral tone.

# Vocabulary

Audio

Flashcards

| No. | Word | Pinyin | Part of Speech | Definition |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 你 | *nǐ* | pr | you |
| 2 | 好 | *hǎo* | adj | fine, good, nice, OK, it's settled |
| 3 | 请 | *qǐng* | v | please (polite form of request), to treat or to invite (somebody) |
| 4 | 问 | *wèn* | v | to ask (a question) |
| 5 | 贵 | *guì* | adj | honorable, expensive |
| 6 | 姓 | *xìng* | v/n | (one's) family name is . . . ; family name [See Grammar 1.] |
| 7 | 我 | *wǒ* | pr | I, me |
| 8 | 呢 | *ne* | qp | (question particle) [See Grammar 2.] |
| 9 | 小姐 | *xiǎojiě* | n | Miss, young lady |
| 10 | 叫 | *jiào* | v | to be called, to call [See Grammar 3.] |
| 11 | 什么 | *shénme* | qpr | what |
| 12 | 名字 | *míngzi* | n | name |
| 13 | 先生 | *xiānsheng* | n | Mr., husband, teacher |
| 14 | 李友 | *Lǐ Yǒu* | pn | (a personal name) |
| | 李 | *lǐ* | pn/n | (a family name); plum |
| 15 | 王朋 | *Wáng Péng* | pn | (a personal name) |
| | 王 | *wáng* | pn/n | (a family name); king |

## How About You?

你叫什么名字？

*Nǐ jiào shénme míngzi?*

What is your name?

我叫 _____。

*Wǒ jiào* _____.

# Grammar

## 1 The verb 姓 (*xìng*)

姓 (*xìng*) is both a noun and a verb. When it is used as a verb, it must be followed by an object.

**A** Q: 你姓什么？ A: 我姓李。

*Nǐ xìng shénme?* *Wǒ xìng Lǐ.*

What is your family name? My family name is Li.

姓 (*xìng*) is usually negated with 不 (*bù*). [See Grammar 7.]

**B** Q: 你姓李吗？ A: 我不姓李。 [✗ 我不姓。]

*Nǐ xìng Lǐ ma?* *Wǒ bú xìng Lǐ.*

Is your family name Li? My family name is not Li.

The polite way to ask for and give a family name is as follows.

**C** Q: 你贵姓？ [✗ 你贵姓什么？]

*Nǐ guì xìng?*

What is your family name?
(Lit. Your honorable family name is . . . ?)

Remember to drop the honorific 贵 (*guì*) when you reply.

A: 我姓王。 [✗ 我贵姓王。]

*Wǒ xìng Wáng.*

My family name is Wang.

You can also respond to 你贵姓 (*nǐ guì xìng*) by saying 免贵姓王 (*miǎn guì xìng Wáng*), 免贵姓李 (*miǎn guì xìng Lǐ*). (Lit. Dispense with "honorable." [My] family name is Wang/Li.)

### EXERCISES

Complete these exchanges with your own family name.

1 Q: 请问，你贵姓？ A: 我姓_____。

2 Q: 你姓什么？ A: 我姓_____。

## 2 Questions ending with 呢 *(ne)*

呢 *(ne)* often follows a noun or pronoun to form a question when the content of the question is already clear from the context.

**A**

Q: 请问，你贵姓？
*Qǐng wèn, nǐ guì xìng?*
What's your family name, please?

A: 我姓李，你呢？
*Wǒ xìng Lǐ, nǐ ne?*
My family name is Li. How about you?

**B**

Q: 你叫什么名字？
*Nǐ jiào shénme míngzi?*
What's your name?

A: 我叫王朋，你呢？
*Wǒ jiào Wáng Péng, nǐ ne?*
My name is Wang Peng. How about you?

When 呢 *(ne)* is used in this way, there must be some context. In each of the two examples above, the context is provided by the preceding sentence: 我姓李 *(wǒ xìng Lǐ)* in (A), and 我叫王朋 *(wǒ jiào Wáng Péng)* in (B).

*You're at the first meeting of your college's Chinese Student Association. What is this sophomore's name?*

### EXERCISES

In pairs, ask and give your name and family name.

1 Q: 我姓_____，你呢？ A: 我姓_____。

2 Q: 我叫_____，你呢？ A: 我叫_____。

## 3 The verb 叫 (*jiào*)

While 叫 (*jiào*) has several meanings, it means "to be called" in this lesson. Like 姓 (*xìng*), it must be followed by an object, which can be either a full name or a given name, but seldom a given name that consists only of one syllable.

**A** Q: 你叫什么名字？ A: 我叫王小朋。

*Nǐ jiào shénme míngzi?* *Wǒ jiào Wáng Xiǎopéng.*

What is your name? My name is Wang Xiaopeng.

叫 (*jiào*) is usually negated with 不 (*bù*). [See Grammar 7.]

**B** Q: 你叫李生吗？ A: 我不叫李生。

*Nǐ jiào Lǐ Shēng ma?* *Wǒ bú jiào Lǐ Shēng.*

Is your name Li Sheng? My name is not Li Sheng.

### EXERCISES

Take turns answering the questions below.

1 Q: 请问，你叫什么名字？ A: 我叫_____。

2 Q: 你叫李好吗？ A: 我不叫_____。

## 4 Subject + verb + object

From the examples in the previous Grammar Points, we can see that the basic word order in a Chinese sentence is subject + verb + object.

The word order remains the same in statements and questions. You don't place the question word at the beginning of a question as you do in English, unless that question word is the subject. [See also Grammar 3, Lesson 2, and Grammar 1, Lesson 4.]